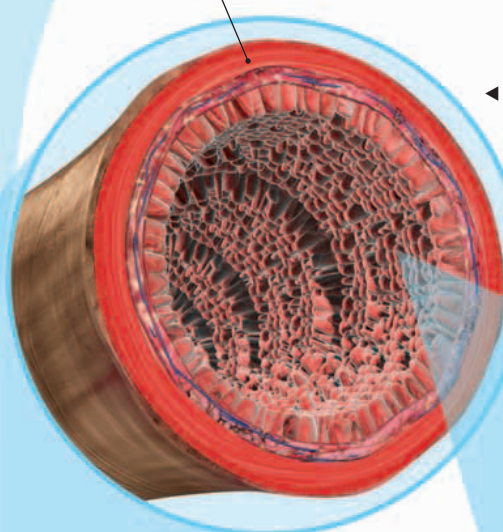




Muscular wall



◀ **INSIDE VIEW** This cross-section of the small intestine reveals its structure. Muscles in its wall create wavelike contractions that both mix food and move it onward. The lining is covered with tiny, fingerlike bumps called villi.



WOW!

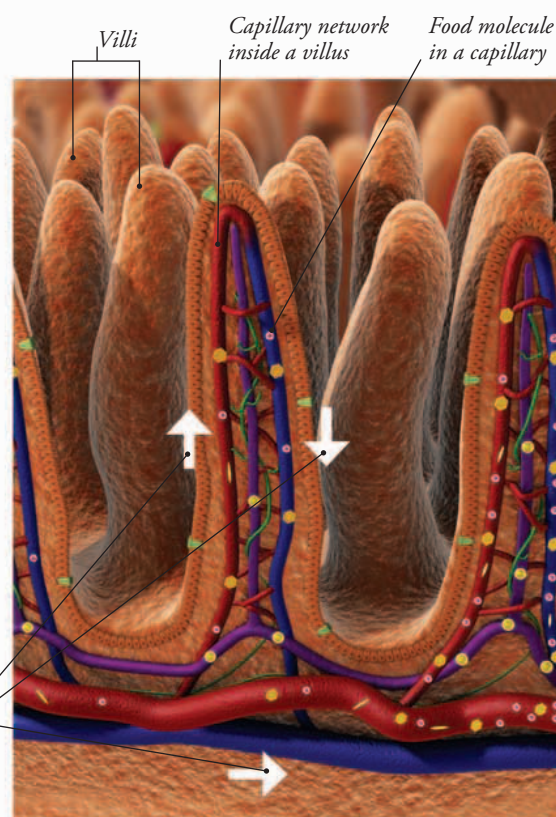
The small intestine is coiled inside the abdomen, but stretched out it would be as long as four adults laid head to toe.

► **VILLI** These are some of the millions of microscopic villi lining the small intestine. Villi provide a huge surface area for digestion and absorption to take place. If stretched out, the villi in your small intestine would cover an area roughly the size of a tennis court.

DIGEST AND ABSORB

Inside the small intestine, enzymes attached to the surface of villi complete the process of digestion. They break down food into simple nutrients—glucose, amino acids, and fatty acids.

► **ABSORPTION** Glucose and amino acids are absorbed into the capillary networks inside villi and are carried in the blood to the liver for processing. Fatty acids enter lymph capillaries (green) for their journey to the liver.



▲ **IN THE MIDDLE** The small intestine, which winds its way from the stomach to the large intestine, takes up much of the space in the abdomen.